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Professor Elijah Coleman
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Dear Professor Coleman,

This letter will serve as my submission for Project 4 in your English 402 class this semester. It will cover everything relating to my information interview final project. This includes my methods for creating the interview questions, the medium in which the interview was conducted, key findings from the interview, and my primary takeaways. I chose to conduct this interview rather than the other option for Project 4, which was to redesign a previous submission from an earlier project in this class, because I felt that this option would provide me with valuable information that I can use to build my career and portfolio. Ultimately, my interview with Joaquin gave me insight into the importance of online certifications, the intense learning curve of network engineering, and the accountability the role requires because of how many people rely on you.

Introduction

After careful consideration, I chose to interview my personal friend, Joaquin Mendoza, for this project. Joaquin works for the city of Moscow as a professional network technician. Although the City of Moscow isn't the specific company that I hope to find myself working at in the future, I do hope to work in an organization with a similar scale and scope. The role of professional network technician, however, is one of my dream positions. For these reasons, I sent a formal interview proposal to Joaquin's business email. He responded to me shortly afterwards, expressing his desire to move forward with the interview.

Methodologies

Before the interview day, I needed to finalize my interview questions and ask myself what I aimed to gain from them. After brainstorming for a while, I came up with some ideas of what I was looking for. First, I wanted to become familiar with the process that Joaquin went through to get this position and what the most difficult or important aspects of it were. Then, I wanted to know what a standard shift looks like for him. I followed that up with what some of the extreme edge case scenarios that he rarely encounters might be. Finally, I wanted to ask him what his future plans are and where he sees himself a few years down the road. I would assume that, because we have similar career interests, our future career goals would line up closely; however, if that wasn't the case, I would want to know how his plans differ from mine. With this basic outline of questions, I hoped to satisfy many of my own curiosities. I also hoped that I might be able to learn some important career lessons through him instead of on my own.

After I was content with the questions that I had drafted, I was ready to move forward and conduct the interview. In my initial interview proposal, I suggested that Joaquin and I meet at The Cougar, a bar in Pullman, WA. This provided a more casual setting that I hoped would encourage the conversations to be more personal and realistic. On Saturday, May 2nd, Joaquin and I met up at The Cougar and found ourselves a table to sit at. I had informed him beforehand that the interview would likely take around half an hour, but it ended up being closer to an hour, primarily because we both enjoyed talking about networking concepts and systems. I decided to use a voice recorder mobile app to record the entire interview because I felt like trying to stay engaged with the conversation would be difficult if I were also trying to type out everything we were saying into a transcript. As I went through my list of questions, I would often think of follow-up questions to keep the conversations going. This allowed me to dig deeper into topics that I didn't think of asking until we were actually talking. Eventually, I had exhausted my list of questions. At this point, I decided to keep the interview going because there were some other questions that I had for Joaquin after our conversations. About an hour after we started the interview, we concluded, and I stopped my voice memo recording. Once I got back to my desk, I was able to listen to the recording and transcribe everything into a document.

Key Findings

This interview was a great opportunity to learn about my desired area of work from a primary source. It allowed me to see through a unique perspective, where I heard about the specific duties that must be carried out on a day-to-day basis. More specifically, I learned that it is essential that I make myself familiar with the various aspects of digital networking, whether that be by earning online certifications or by performing my own personal projects, before I jump into this career path. However, once you get to the point where you can visualize how all the different aspects of the field work together, such as physical device networking, internet protocol variation, and firewall configuration, it becomes significantly easier to learn new things and expand your skillset. Joaquin described this point as "the point where everything clicks, and you really start to understand it all." Knowing this as I move forward in my own career will help me keep my motivation stable and avoid becoming discouraged when presented with complicated problems that may feel unsolvable at first.

Takeaways

Ultimately, I feel like this interview with Joaquin will prove to be invaluable as I move forward in my career. He described the process of getting your first entry-level job offer in the field as difficult and discouraging, but he also encouraged me to keep trying until I get it. In the realm of cybersecurity and, more specifically, network engineering, many people depend on you to keep the system working correctly and efficiently to do their own jobs. Joaquin oftentimes finds himself having to fix issues for the police station or fire department, both of which are essential to the functionality of a city. It is a heavy responsibility and requires extreme reliability and attention to detail, but that is exactly the kind of position I want to be in. Completing this project has helped me gain a better understanding of my own career goals as well as what steps I need to take in order to achieve them. Because of this, I am grateful for this opportunity and would like to thank you for presenting it to me.

Sincerely,
Owen Downs

APPENDIX

BIBLIOGRAPHY

Mendoza, Joaquin. Personal interview. 2 May 2026.

INTERVIEW QUESTIONS & NOTES

Question: What is your job title?

Notes: Joaquin Mendoza introduced himself and explained that his current role is “Network Administrator for the City of Moscow”. He works in the information systems department.

Question: How did you find your current position?

Notes: He applied on Indeed and didn’t hear anything back for a little over 4 months. By the time he heard back, he didn’t remember applying. The city contacted him and called him in for an interview. After the interview, he started working as a network administrator technician. Only after working in that role for a year did he hear about the network administrator position opening and apply for it. He was able to get the job.

Question: For what reasons were you interested in your current position?

Notes: Joaquin explained how he initially got introduced to Cisco networking in high school while he was participating in the Running Start program at Spokane Community College. He has been invested in it ever since. When he wanted to apply for the promotion mentioned in the previous question, he was told that he needed either a CCNA certification or a Network+ certification. He studied for about 4 months before taking the CCNA exam and passing, earning him his certification.

Question: Was this job the type of job that you were initially searching for?

Notes: Ever since high school, he knew that he wanted to get into the field of systems networking. Through his time in FBLA (Future Business Leaders of America), Joaquin realized that he loved working with network engineering and management. In fact, he was able to take 5th place in the nation for this performance as a network engineer for FBLA.

Question: What does a normal day’s worth of work look like in this position?

Notes: Joaquin explained that his role is pretty isolated compared to the rest of the department. His daily duties focus on maintaining network security and general network management. Some common issues he encounters are figuring out why the network is slow and figuring out why the network traffic is well above average. He also handles creating and managing the firewall rules to dictate what kind of network traffic is allowed in/out of the city.

Question: Out of the skills that you commonly use at your job, which of them were the most difficult to learn?

Notes: Joaquin talked about how the hardest part of his first position was “talking on the phone”. This caught me off guard because I didn’t imagine he had to do that very often. He explained to me that in his first position, since he was at a low level, he would be the first person a lot of people were told to call for network issues. From there, he would either solve the issue himself or escalate it to the professionals. Since he was on call 24/7, he had to be ready to respond to an issue coming up at any moment and talk to whoever needed assistance.

Question: What skills or knowledge did you have before starting your current position that you still commonly use?

Notes: After some thinking, Joaquin told me that one of the skills he uses every day is managing switches and firewalls directly through the command line instead of through a GUI. This saves a lot of time, but requires thorough knowledge of all the commands and how to use them. There are also certain things that using the command line enables you to do that might not be available as a feature on the GUI apps. He describes it as “a big learning curve, but once you get it, your skills like... *hand gestures expanding outwards*.”

Question: If you were hiring for your current position, what kind of person would you be searching for to fit the role?

Notes: Joaquin told me that “skills can always be taught for the most part,” implying that he wouldn't worry too much about the candidate's technical knowledge or skills. He said that the most important skill to have would be “problem solving.” He said that sometimes you're in a situation where you really don't know where to start, and the only feedback he can get is to “figure it out”. He says that problem-solving is the #1 skill because it proves you can do your own research, for example by reading through forums and documentation, to solve problems where the solution isn't obvious. When it comes to more personal skills, he expressed that the ability to communicate clearly is very important. He referred back to all the times he had to answer the phone and try to guide someone through a process. It isn't always easy to do this, especially when most of the people you'll be on the phone with aren't particularly tech savvy. One strategy he uses to explain technical situations is to use analogies to relate what's happening to situations that the person on the other end of the line might be more familiar with.

Question: What future career plans do you have, and where do you see yourself a few years down the road from now?

Notes: He mentioned that he would like to move towards the incident response side of networking. He plans to move out of Pullman sometime soon because his girlfriend is graduating. Because of this, he has been looking for positions in the Spokane and Seattle areas. Later on, in a different follow-up question, he explained to me that he is looking to get his CCNP, which is the direct step up from his current certification level.

Question: What is your dream career goal? In other words, what position do you want to be in at the end of your ideal career?

Notes: Generally, after he gets more experience, he wants to move to a role that's more cybersecurity-focused. One example of this would be a “threat hunter.” These are people who respond to cybersecurity incidents and go through network logs and architecture to find possible vulnerabilities or evidence of a breach. He really wants to get to the point where he can track down people who may have infiltrated a network structure in some way.